Same Problem, Different Solutions

Civic Skill: Difference | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 4 (Learning) & Outcome 2 (Community) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will encounter a shared problem and discover that different people can solve it differently — and that multiple valid solutions can exist at the same time.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can listen to someone else's solution even when it's different from mine.
- I can say 'that works too' when I see a different approach succeed.
- I can find more than one solution to a problem.

MATERIALS

- A hands-on problem: build a bridge for a toy to cross a 'river' (tape on floor), using only the materials provided
- Materials: cardboard tubes, popsicle sticks, fabric, rubber bands, tape — enough for 3–4 groups
- A puppet or toy to test each bridge
- Picture book: 'Beautiful Oops!' by Barney Saltzberg

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. BOOK OPENER (5 min): Read 'Beautiful Oops!' — the central idea is that when things go 'wrong,' they can become something else entirely. Mistakes are not dead ends. Different is not failure.

2. PROBLEM PRESENTATION (3 min): Show the river and the toy. 'Our toy needs to get across. Your group needs to build something that works. There is no one right way — just ways that work and ways we learn from.'

3. BUILD TIME (10 min): Groups build independently. Educator asks process questions: 'Why did you choose that?' 'What will happen if ___?' Avoid solving problems for groups — let them encounter obstacles.

4. BRIDGE TESTING (5 min): Each group tests their bridge with the toy. Celebrate all bridges that work. For bridges that don't quite work: 'What would you change? What did you learn?'

5. COMPARE AND CELEBRATE (5 min): 'Look at our three bridges. They're all different. Did they all work? How is this like people — different ways, but all getting somewhere?'

EXTENSIONS

- Extend to a real classroom problem: 'We need to organise our book corner. What are three different ways we could do it?' Try one together.
- Drama extension: the same story, two endings — act out both and discuss which feels right
- Connect to STEM: investigate 'which bridge holds the most weight' — honouring both the creative and the analytical approach

ASSESSMENT

- Observation: Did children in groups negotiate whose approach to try, or did one person dominate?
- Key question: 'What did you do when someone had a different idea from you?'
- Note which children initiated peer consultation — 'What do you think we should try?'

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- How did you handle groups that got stuck in conflict about whose approach to use?
- Did the children experience genuine surprise at a different solution working? What did that look like?

- How could you make 'multiple valid solutions' a daily norm in learning conversations?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 4 (Learning) & Outcome 2 (Community). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.